

■ Decision Fatigue

■ What is it?

Feeling worn out from too many choices.

Our ability to make good decisions gets weaker the more choices we face.

For example, think of the last time you shopped online. After hours of comparing items, you felt too tired to decide—and just closed the site.

■■ History

The concept of decision fatigue became popular in the early **2000s**, thanks to research by social psychologist **Roy Baumeister**.

He showed that making repeated decisions uses up mental energy, just like a muscle gets tired after exercise. As energy runs low, people either make worse choices—or avoid making them at all.

■ The Psychology Behind It

Every choice uses up a bit of willpower. As the day goes on and decisions pile up, the brain becomes overloaded.

This leads to:

- Poor judgment
- Impulsive decisions
- Avoiding decisions completely

In design, too many options can exhaust users and push them to leave.

■■ Why It Matters

Decision fatigue can cause:

- Reduced motivation
- Higher error rates
- Negative emotional responses
- Drop-offs from overwhelmed users

■ How to Apply It

- **Simplify choices** → highlight most popular or best-reviewed options.
- **Offer defaults** → preselect values to reduce effort.
- **Use intuitive design** → clear navigation and layouts.
- **Progressive disclosure** → reveal steps gradually instead of all at once.
- **Visual guides** → CTAs, labels, and progress indicators for clarity.

■ Theory in Action

- **Amazon's "Recommended for You"** feature cuts decision fatigue by suggesting relevant products.
- **Cafés** use "Today's Special" menus to simplify decisions and reduce choice overload.

■ Final Thought

Too many options can push users to give up instead of choosing. Good design makes life easier by guiding decisions, simplifying choices, and keeping users energized.